This is unquestionably the arena for the contemporary version of the Great Game, where multiple players with diverse ambitions display their strategic skills. Their efforts at building convergences and understanding contestation will have a particular importance as it takes place on a global lifeline.

The Indo-Pacific may be in fashion as a strategic concept now. But it has been an economic and cultural fact for centuries. After all, Indians and Arabs have left their imprint all the way up to the eastern coast of China, just as the people of South-East Asia did on Africa. In fact, this reality is not remote at all and the seamlessness of waters only sharpened the appetite of the Western powers who entered it. The British Empire operated its own version of the Indo-Pacific that was neither free nor open. Its visualization of both resources and interests was across an integrated zone, explaining many of the events of the nineteenth and twentieth century.

Other powers, in turn, followed the approach of the dominant one. If Indian troops fought in the Boxer Rebellion, then the Japanese too came all the way to Singapore and Burma. And not least, it was the enormous logistical effort from India by the Anglo-American alliance that sustained China in its war against Japan after 1942. The earlier era of the Indo-Pacific lasted until 1945 and was reflected in the presence of British and American forces across the region. After the war, Indian troops were deployed in seven prefectures of Chugoku and Shikoku in Japan. And the 2/5 Gurkhas even mounted guard at the Imperial Palace in Tokyo. What separated the Indian and Pacific theatres thereafter was the global supersession of the UK by the US. That shifted the centre of gravity to the Pacific, strengthened thereafter by the revolution in China and the war in Korea. As for the UK, India’s independence and its own falling back to the Gulf focused its interest westwards. The result was that a continuum gave way to narrower domains that were solidified by military command jurisdictions. The Indo-Pacific is as much our past as it is our future. Whether it is, therefore, strategically viable depends on the politics of the day, as it did before.

For our purposes, what is important is that just as the dominance of the US undid Indo-Pacific after 1945, American adjustments now can help reinvent it. This may happen not just by itself but because there are also other